touchingly generous, in fact, about the irascible Beg's loyalty to Humayun's son, given how much cause he had to be suspicious – not of Akbar, but of Bairam.

The two senior commanders had been at loggerheads for a while. Only a few months earlier, Tardi Beg and Bairam Khan had disagreed on whether or not to pursue some enemy troops; the fight escalated until Humayun had to call a peace meeting to sort things out.

Tardi Beg was not the only thorn in Bairam Khan's side. There was also the good-looking Shah Abul Ma'ali. The two men hated each other. Bairam Khan was descended from a high-ranking nobleman; his family had been marrying Timurids for five generations; his father had joined Babur's forces before Babur even held Kabul, let alone Agra, and Bairam had stuck by Humayun's side through some of the emperor's worst times. Abul Ma'ali, claiming sayyid descent,[9] had arrived on the scene only recently and, for no clear reason except that he was exceedingly handsome and flaunted both courage and impudence, he had gained Humayun's favour.[10]

Besides, Bairam Khan was Shia, and Abul Ma'ali was not. A year or so earlier, Humayun had gone to visit Bairam Khan in Qandahar. Abul Ma'ali, who was part of the emperor's entourage, had taken particular dislike to a Shia he found in Bairam's service – a defector from Iran who had gained the khan's protection and wanted to join Humayun's court. Abul Ma'ali would often declare, in public, that he would 'kill this heretical fellow'.[11] Such threats were evidently not uncommon, because Humayun took it 'as a pleasantry', until Abul Ma'ali did, in fact, murder the poor Shia.[12] When summoned by Humayun, Abul Ma'ali 'swaggered drunken into the royal assembly',[13] wearing the dead man's clothes and the sword he'd used to kill him. His gall inspired Bairam Khan to recite an impromptu, enraged bit of verse, 'His dishevelled locks of hair / Lo! a blazing proof is there . . .'[14]

Humayun applauded the rhyme, but let the criminal go free. If he hoped the two men's differences would dissolve in the camaraderie of the Hindustan campaign, he was wrong. Bairam Khan and Abul Ma'ali both led troops in the battle of Sirhind; and afterwards they both stood bristling before Humayun, demanding sole credit for the victory. Once again, Humayun took the path of least resistance and declared the victory Akbar's. But now, Humayun was gone, and with him any hope of even such